CIVIL SERVICES EXAMINATION

UPSC • GENERAL STUDIES — PAPER 1

Modern Indian History

From the Advent of Europeans to Freedom Struggle & Independence

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CHAPTER 1

Advent of Europeans and British Conquest of Bengal

1.1 Historical Context: 18th Century India and European Arrivals

The eighteenth century in Indian history was marked by two transformative transitions: the internal fragmentation of the Mughal Empire after the death of Aurangzeb (1707) and the external penetration and eventual political ascendancy of European mercantile companies.

> **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **The Dual Nature of the 18th Century Transition:**
> 1. **Internal Reorganisation:** Decline of centralised Mughal authority led to the emergence of successor states (Bengal, Awadh, Hyderabad), independent warrior kingdoms (Maratha confederacy, Mysore, Sikhs), and warrior-peasant polities (Jats, Rohillas).
> 2. **External Transition:** European trading corporations shifted from commercial interaction under imperial charters (*firmans*) to active political and territorial intervention, backed by fiscal-military statecraft.

1.1.1 Sequence of European Commercial Arrivals

Between the late 15th and 17th centuries, multiple European maritime nations established trading posts (*factories*) along the Indian coastline:

- **The Portuguese (1498):** Vasco da Gama landed at Calicut in May 1498 (received by Zamorin). Francisco de Almeida (first Viceroy, 1505) initiated the *Blue Water Policy* (*Cartaze* system). Afonso de Albuquerque (1509) captured Goa from the Sultan of Bijapur (1510) and established Portuguese naval dominance in the Indian Ocean.
- **The Dutch East India Company / VOC (1602):** Established factories at Masulipatnam (1605), Pulicat (1610), Surat (1616), Chinsurah (1653). Their primary trade focus was cotton textiles, indigo, raw silk, and saltpetre, eventually shifting commercial priority toward the spice islands of the Indonesian archipelago. Defeated by Marthanda Varma of Travancore in the **Battle of Colachel (1741)** and by the English in the **Battle of Bedara/Chinsurah (1759)**.
- **The English East India Company (1600):** Granted a royal charter with a 15-year commercial monopoly by Queen Elizabeth I on 31 December 1600. Captain William Hawkins visited the court of Jahangir (1608); Sir Thomas Roe obtained imperial concessions (1615). Key settlements: Madras (Fort St. George, 1639), Bombay (acquired from Charles II in 1668), Calcutta (Fort William, established by Job Charnock in 1690 by combining Sutanuti, Kalikata, and Gobindapur).

- **The French East India Company / *Compagnie des Indes* (1664):** Founded under Jean-Baptiste Colbert during the reign of Louis XIV. Established their first factory at Surat (1668) under Francois Caron and at Masulipatnam (1669). Founded Pondicherry (1674) under Francois Martin and Chandernagore in Bengal (1690).

COMPARISON

Comparison of European Trading Entities in India:

Power	Key Settlements	Nature of Enterprise
Portuguese	Goa, Daman, Diu, Cochin	Crown monopoly; religious intolerance; private corruption led to early decline.
Dutch	Pulicat, Chinsurah, Nagapattinam	Semi-private merchant consortium; pivot to spice trade in the East Indies.
English	Calcutta, Madras, Bombay	Private joint-stock corporation; strong naval logistics, institutional financial backing.
French	Pondicherry, Chandernagore, Mahe	State-controlled company; vulnerable to political shifts and finances in Paris.

1.2 Anglo-French Rivalry: The Carnatic Wars (1746–1763)

The Carnatic region (the coastal hinterland of the Coromandel coast under the theoretical suzerainty of the Nizam of Hyderabad) became the primary theatre of military contest between the English and French East India Companies.

1.2.1 First Carnatic War (1746–1748)

- **Immediate Cause:** Extension of the War of the Austrian Succession in Europe (1740–1748).
- **Key Military Event: Battle of St. Thome / Battle of the Adyar (1746)**, where a disciplined, artillery-equipped French force of under 1,000 men commanded by Captain Paradise decisively defeated the 10,000-strong army of Anwar-ud-din, the Nawab of Carnatic.
- **Significance:** Demonstrated the absolute tactical superiority of small, European-trained infantry and rapid-firing artillery over large, traditional Indian cavalry-led feudal armies.
- **Conclusion:** Treaty of Aix-la-Chapelle (1748), restoring Madras to the British in exchange for Louisbourg in North America.

1.2.2 Second Carnatic War (1749–1754)

- **Nature:** Internal dynastic succession disputes in Hyderabad (Nasir Jung vs. Muzaffar Jung) and the Carnatic (Anwar-ud-din vs. Chanda Sahib).
- **Role of Dupleix:** Joseph Francois Dupleix pioneered the political technique of subverting native state autonomy by intervening in disputed successions, supplying European-trained

contingents in exchange for territorial assignments and revenue concessions.

- **British Counter-offensive:** Robert Clive staged a daring diversionary capture and 53-day defence of Arcot (1751), shifting military momentum in favor of Muhammad Ali (British ally).
- **Outcome:** Dupleix recalled by the French directors in 1754; Treaty of Pondicherry (1754) signed by Godeheu.

1.2.3 Third Carnatic War (1758–1763) and Decisive British Victory

- **European Context:** Seven Years' War (1756–1763).
- **Turning Point: Battle of Wandiwash (22 January 1760)**, where British General Sir Eyre Coote crushed the French army under Count de Lally.
- **Settlement:** Treaty of Paris (1763). French factories in India were restored only as non-fortified commercial establishments, permanently extinguishing French political and military ambitions in the subcontinent.

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Why the British Succeeded Over the French in India:**
> 1. **Corporate Autonomy:** The British EIC was a private joint-stock enterprise governed by shareholders with commercial agility, whereas the French Company was a state-run bureaucratic entity perpetually starved of funds and subject to royal whims.
> 2. **Naval Supremacy:** The Royal Navy maintained uninterrupted supply lines and communication between Britain, Bombay, Madras, and Calcutta.
> 3. **Base of Operations in Bengal:** After 1757, the British controlled the immense agricultural surplus and trade revenues of Bengal, which funded military campaigns in the South, while the French relied on financially strained Pondicherry.

1.3 Conquest of Bengal: From Commercial Privileges to Sovereignty

1.3.1 Bengal's Strategic and Economic Stature

Bengal was the wealthiest province (*subah*) of the Mughal Empire, contributing nearly 60% of British imports from Asia. Murshid Quli Khan (Governor from 1717) established hereditary rule while remitting regular tribute to Delhi. He was succeeded by Shuja-ud-din, Sarfaraz Khan, and Alivardi Khan (1740–1756), who kept European companies under strict administrative control.

1.3.2 Friction with Siraj-ud-Daulah and the Farman of 1717

When Alivardi Khan died in April 1756, his 23-year-old grandson **Siraj-ud-Daulah** succeeded him amidst severe court factionalism (Ghaseti Begum, Shaukat Jung, Mir Jafar).

> **GOVERNMENT & POLICY**
>
> **The Farman of Emperor Farrukhsiyar (1717) — The 'Magna Carta' of the EIC:**
> In 1717, Emperor Farrukhsiyar issued a royal decree granting the British East India Company:
>
> - Exemption from custom duties in Bengal in return for an annual fixed payment of Rs. 3,000.
> - Right to issue *dastaks* (passes) for duty-free transit of goods belonging to Company trade.

- Right to mint Company coins at Bombay for imperial circulation.

Misuse and Conflict: Company servants routinely used *dastaks* for illicit private inland trade, evading duties and causing catastrophic revenue losses to the Bengal state treasury while placing Indian native merchants at a crippling competitive disadvantage.

1.3.3 Escalation to Plassey (1756–1757)

Siraj-ud-Daulah ordered both the French and English to cease unauthorised fortifications in Chandernagore and Calcutta. The French complied; the British refused. Siraj marched on Calcutta, captured Fort William (June 1756), and renamed it Alinagar.

- **Black Hole Incident (June 1756):** Alleged confinement of British prisoners in a small room, heavily sensationalised by J.Z. Holwell to justify military retribution.
- **Clive's Retaliation:** Robert Clive and Admiral Watson arrived from Madras with naval and ground forces, recapturing Calcutta in January 1757 and concluding the Treaty of Alinagar (February 1757).
- **The Secret Conspiracy:** Clive engineered a coup with dissident nobles: Mir Jafar (Commander-in-Chief / *Mir Bakshi*), Jagat Seth (imperial banker), Omichand (merchant mediator), Rai Durlabh, and Manikchand.

1.3.4 Battle of Plassey (23 June 1757)

Fought on the banks of the Bhagirathi river near Palashi. Mir Jafar's large division remained idle on the battlefield while loyal officers Mir Madan and Mohan Lal fell fighting. Siraj fled to Murshidabad, was captured, and assassinated on the orders of Mir Jafar's son, Miran.

DATA & FACTS

Material Consequences of Plassey (1757):

1. Mir Jafar was installed as Nawab and ceded the **Zamindari of 24 Parganas** to the Company.
2. The Company received over Rs. 1.77 crore in war indemnities, plus personal gifts of Rs. 23.4 lakh to Clive.
3. Clive later noted that Plassey was not a great military victory, but a transaction of high treason that transformed the Company from merchants into kingmakers.

1.4 From Mir Jafar to Mir Qasim and the Battle of Buxar (1764)

1.4.1 Mir Qasim's Administrative Reforms and Defiance

Mir Jafar's inability to satisfy the Company's perpetual financial greed led to his replacement in 1760 by his son-in-law, **Mir Qasim**, who ceded Burdwan, Midnapore, and Chittagong. Mir Qasim was an able administrator who sought genuine independence:

- Shifted the provincial capital from Murshidabad to **Munger (Bihar)** to distance his court from British surveillance in Calcutta.
- Established an arms and munitions factory at Munger to forge muskets and cast artillery on modern European models.

- Reorganised provincial finances, collected arrears, and imposed an additional *abwab* (tax).
- **Abolition of Internal Transit Duties:** When Company officials refused to cease abusing *dastaks*, Mir Qasim took the radical step of abolishing all inland transit duties for Indian and foreign merchants alike, equalising market competition. The Calcutta Council declared this an act of war.

1.4.2 The Battle of Buxar (22 October 1764)

Defeated in a series of skirmishes in 1763 (Katwa, Gheria, Udaynala), Mir Qasim formed a grand tripartite confederacy with:

1. **Shuja-ud-Daulah**, Nawab of Awadh.
2. **Shah Alam II**, fugitive Mughal Emperor.
3. **Mir Qasim**, dispossessed Nawab of Bengal.

Major **Hector Munro** commanded the British forces against the combined allied army at Buxar (western Bihar).

COMPARISON

Plassey (1757) vs. Buxar (1764) — Analytical Contrast:

Dimension	Battle of Plassey (1757)	Battle of Buxar (1764)
Nature of Conflict	A skirmish settled by pre-arranged treachery and betrayal.	A pitched, full-scale military battle against disciplined allied units.
Opponent	A young, isolated provincial Nawab (Siraj-ud-Daulah).	Combined confederacy of the Mughal Emperor, Awadh, and Bengal.
Geopolitical Result	Gave the British commercial monopoly and kingmaker status in Bengal.	Established undisputed British military supremacy across Northern India.
Constitutional Impact	Indirect influence through puppet Nawabs.	De jure legal grant of imperial sovereignty via the Treaty of Allahabad.

1.5 The Treaty of Allahabad (1765) and the Dual Government (1765–1772)

Robert Clive returned as Governor of Bengal in May 1765 and concluded two historic treaties at Allahabad in August 1765:

1.5.1 Treaty with Shah Alam II (12 August 1765)

- The Mughal Emperor granted the **Diwani** (right of civil justice and revenue collection) of **Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa** in perpetuity to the English East India Company.

- In return, the Company secured districts of Kora and Allahabad (carved out of Awadh) for the Emperor and promised an annual imperial tribute of Rs. 26 lakh.

1.5.2 Treaty with Shuja-ud-Daulah of Awadh (16 August 1765)

- Awadh was restored to the Nawab on payment of a war indemnity of Rs. 50 lakh.
- Awadh was turned into a **buffer state** against potential Maratha invasions.
- British troops were stationed in Awadh at the expense of the Nawab.

1.5.3 Mechanism of the Dual Government of Bengal (Dyarchy)

Clive institutionalised a separation of sovereignty into two wings:

- **Diwani:** Revenue collection and civil administration, held directly by the Company under imperial authority.
- **Nizamat:** Military power, criminal justice, and police administration, nominally remaining with the Nawab through a Company-appointed *Naib Subahdar* (Mohammad Reza Khan for Bengal, Raja Shitab Rai for Bihar).

> **CRITICAL POINT**
>
> **Devastating Consequences of Dual Government (1765–1772):**
> 1. **Power Without Responsibility:** The Company possessed all revenue and armed force with zero administrative accountability for the welfare of the populace; the Nawab had total moral responsibility with zero fiscal resources or military means.
> 2. **Destruction of Agriculture and Trade:** Revenue farming was auctioned annually to predatory contractors (*ijaradars*), extorting maximum rent from peasants.
> 3. **The Great Bengal Famine of 1770:** A catastrophic famine decimated an estimated one-third of Bengal's population (approx. 10 million deaths). Despite the famine, Company revenue collections in 1771 actually exceeded those of 1768 due to coercive enforcement.
> 4. **Abolition:** Terminated in 1772 by **Warren Hastings**, who brought the treasury directly to Calcutta and placed revenue administration under European Collectors.

1.6 UPSC Answer Writing Toolkit: Analytical Frameworks

> **PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTION**
>
> **Recent UPSC Mains Questions for Reference:**
> 1. "*The Battle of Plassey was a transaction, while the Battle of Buxar was a test of arms.*" Critically examine. (GS-1 / 15 Marks)
> 2. "*Explain how the English East India Company utilized the Dual Government system to extract maximum economic wealth while evading sovereign governance responsibilities.*" (GS-1 / 10 Marks)
> 3. "*Discuss the strategic and commercial factors that enabled the English East India Company to supersede other European maritime powers in eighteenth-century India.*" (GS-1 / 15 Marks)

QUICK REVISION

Summary of Key Dates and Milestones for Quick Recall:

- **1498:** Vasco da Gama reaches Calicut; Portuguese maritime trade era begins.
- **1600:** EIC chartered by Queen Elizabeth I.
- **1717:** Farrukhsiyar's Farman grants duty-free trade privileges in Bengal.
- **1746–1763:** Three Carnatic Wars end with British victory at Wandiwash (1760).
- **1757 (23 June):** Battle of Plassey establishes British political hegemony in Bengal.
- **1764 (22 October):** Battle of Buxar confirms British military supremacy over allied North Indian powers.
- **1765:** Treaty of Allahabad; grant of Diwani rights of Bengal, Bihar, and Orissa.
- **1765–1772:** Clive's Dual System of Government; ends with Warren Hastings in 1772.

CHAPTER GLOSSARY

- **Dastak:** Trade permit issued by the Company's Calcutta council exempting goods from transit toll taxes under the 1717 Farman.
- **Diwani:** Sovereign authority over civil justice and revenue administration under Mughal constitutional law.
- **Nizamat:** Executive functions of statecraft, specifically military defense, internal policing, and criminal judicature.
- **Cartaz System:** Maritime pass system enforced by Portuguese naval patrols requiring merchant vessels to buy protection licenses.
- **Abwab:** Miscellaneous cesses, levies, and customary taxes imposed above the standard land revenue demand.
- **Buffer State:** A neutral or dependent sovereign state positioned between two rival powers (e.g., Awadh between British Bengal and the Marathas).